

Hannah Szabó

Syntax II — Spring 2024

Professor Jim Wood

Hungarian *az*-Focusing: Expletive Insertion or Internal Movement?

§1. Introduction

In some languages, displacement of a constituent can serve the discursive function of topicalization or focusing (Szendrői 2017). For example, in English, the focused constituent of a sentence is typically marked with phonological stress (1a, marked throughout this analysis with an underline), but can additionally be displaced from its canonical position in the process of clefting (1b, marked with a trace).

- (1) a. John found the key.
 b. It was [the key]_i that John found <*t_i*>.

Hungarian focusing is loosely analogous to English clefting (1b) in that it simultaneously involves both prosodic marking and syntactic displacement (Kenesei 2006: 2). In sentence (2), the default SVO Hungarian word order changes to SOV in order to place the object in the preverbal Focus position; the displaced object receives phonological stress.

- (2) János [az imá-t] mond-ja <*t_i*>
John the prayer-ACC say-PRS.3SG <~~*the prayer-ACC*~~>
 ‘John says the prayer.’

The syntactic aspects of Hungarian focusing have been studied extensively by linguists including Horváth (1986, 1995), É. Kiss (2002), Lipták (2003), and Szendrői (2017); in Section 2, I provide an analysis of focus-motivated displacement based on these analyses. However, this explanation does not in itself clarify the underlying syntactic structure of a specific phenomenon known in this paper as *az*-Focusing. Sentences display *az*-Focusing when a Case-inflected version of the demonstrative *az* occupies the Focus position, as in the following examples:

- (3) a. Az-∅ volt biztos, hogy Sandi haza-me-nt
AZ-NOM be.PST.3SG certain that Sandy house-go-PST.3SG
 ‘It was certain that Sandy went home.’
- b. Az-t mond-t-am, hogy boldog vagy-ok
AZ-ACC say-PST-1SG that happy be.PRS-3SG
 ‘I said that I am happy’
- c. Az-ért jö-tt-em, hogy ki-vág-j-am a fá-t
AZ-CAUS come-PST-1SG that off-cut-SBJT-1SG the tree-ACC
 ‘I came to cut down the tree.’

One possible explanation of *az*-Focusing, described in detail in Section 3 of my paper, is that *az* appears as a result of expletive insertion: Hungarian sentences seem to require that the preverbal Focus position is filled, and occurrences of *az*-Focusing pattern with cases when a constituent appears unable to move up to Focus. However, this hypothesis, explored and ultimately rejected in Section 4, is problematic because it requires an Agree relation that violates the Activity Condition as defined by Chomsky (2000). Instead, I posit an alternative hypothesis in Section 5 whereby *az* is a DP Merged into the syntax at Spec-CP that undergoes Internal Merge in order to occupy the Focus position. I show that this alternative hypothesis has compelling evidence, and that it fits well into the broader literature on focusing. Section 6 concludes.

§2: A Description and Derivation of Hungarian Focus Positioning

As an agglutinative language, Hungarian encodes grammatical function through affixes, while word order is used for “backgrounding and/or highlighting information” (Rounds 2009: 240). The expression immediately preceding the main verb occupies the Focus position, so the reordering of words in Hungarian sentences causes the emphasis of different pieces of information:

- (4) a. János tanul-∅ nyelvészet-et az¹ egyetem-en.
John study-PRS.3.SG linguistics-ACC the university-SUPESS
 ‘It is John who studies linguistics at the university.’
- b. Nyelvészet-et tanul-∅ János az egyetem-en.
linguistics-ACC study-PRS.3.SG John the university-SUPESS
 ‘Linguistics is what John studies at the university.’
- c. János az egyetem-en tanul-∅ nyelvészet-et.
John the university-SUPESS study-PRS.3SG linguistics-ACC
 ‘John studies linguistics at the university.’
- d. Tanul-∅ János nyelvészet-et az egyetem-en.’
study-PRS.3SG John linguistics-ACC the university-SUPESS
 ‘John does study linguistics at the university.’

(4d) lacks a phonologically stressed constituent, and the verb is in sentence-initial position, which seems to suggest that the Focus position is empty. However, (4d) has an interpretation known as Verum Focus, wherein emphasis is placed on the fact of the particular action having occurred, against some presupposed doubt. I propose that this situation arises due to the fact that the Focus feature is syntactically filled by an unpronounced intensifier AdvP like

¹ *Az* in (5a) is not the word examined later on in this paper, but rather a version of the definite pronoun *a* occurring prevocally (analogous to the English ‘a’/‘an’ distinction).

tényleg ('indeed') or *valóban* ('truly') which causes the verb itself to be semantically emphasized.²

- (4) e. (~~Tényleg~~) tanul János nyelvészet-et az egyetem-en.'
indeed study John linguistics-ACC the university-SUPERS
 'John does study linguistics at the university.'

Despite this flexibility, word order is not entirely variable in Hungarian. When a sentence contains a *wh*- word (5a), an answer to a question (5b), or a negation (5c), this information must be in the Focus position; otherwise, the sentence is ungrammatical (Rounds 2009, 241):

- (5) a. {Ki-t} lát-ott {*ki-t} Mari {*ki-t}?
 {*who-ACC*} *see-PST.INDEF.3SG* {**who-ACC*} *Mari* {**who-ACC*}
 'Whom did Mary see?'
- b. {*Miki-t} Mari {Miki-t} lát-ta {*Miki-t}.
 {**Nick-ACC*} *Mari* {*Nick-ACC*} *see-PST.DEF.3SG* {**Nick-ACC*}
 Mary saw Nick.
- c. {*Nem} Mari {nem} lát-ta {*nem} Miki-t {*nem}.
 {**NEG*} *Mari* {*NEG*} *see-PST.DEF.3SG* {**NEG*} *Nick-ACC* {**NEG*}
 'Mary did not see Nick'

In his pioneering work on Focus, Jackendoff (1972) introduces "a syntactic feature F which can be associated with any node in the surface structure" that causes the "associated semantic material [to be] the Focus of the sentence" (Jackendoff 1972: 240). Building on Jackendoff, Horváth (1995) notes that in "Hungarian-type languages" that exhibit preverbal focusing, V must carry a [FOCUS] feature (Horváth 1995: 30). É. Kiss (2002) synthesizes these theories,

² Although this explanation of verb-initial sentences is somewhat satisfactory, it is surprising to propose that a word occupying Focus position, which typically receives prosodic stress, is unpronounced. This issue remains outside the scope of the current analysis, but is an interesting topic for future studies.

proposing that Hungarian Focusing is a feature-motivated process analogous to the Extended Projection Principle (EPP), wherein a [FOCUS] feature on the verb must be ‘checked’ by being c-commanded by a constituent also carrying [FOCUS] (É. Kiss 2002: 89). Effectively, this theory of focusing encodes the requirement that Spec-v*P must be occupied by a constituent carrying the [FOCUS] feature. To demonstrate this theory, I provide a formal derivation of sentence (2), in which the object is moved into Focus position:

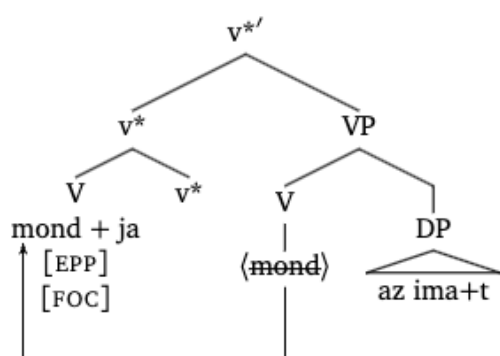
- (2) János az ima-t mond-ja
 John the prayer-ACC say-PRS.3SG
 ‘John says the prayer.’

DERIVATION OF (2)

- i. Merge [_D *az* ‘the’] with [_{NP} *ima* ‘prayer’], projecting [_{DP} *az ima* ‘the prayer’] carrying the features [φ : 3SG], [Case: _] [FOC].
- ii. Merge [_V *mond* ‘say’] with [_{DP} *az ima* ‘the prayer’] to project [_{VP} *mond az ima* ‘say the prayer’].
- iii. The following operations occur simultaneously:
 - a. Merge VP with v*. v* enters the syntax carrying the features [Strong-V] [Case: ACC] [φ : _] [EPP] [FOC].
 - b. Internally Merge [_V *mond* ‘say’] to v* to check [Strong-V]. [_V *mond* ‘say’] inherits the uninterpreted features of v*.
 - c. Agree occurs between [_V *mond* ‘say’] and [_{DP} *az ima* ‘the prayer’]; the former gets its φ feature valued ([φ : 3SG]) and the latter gets its Case feature valued ([Case: _]).
 - d. Each of these valuations results in the affixation of a suffix marking person (+*ja*) or Case (+*t*), respectively.

The intermediate representation, immediately after Agree and Feature Valuation, is represented in the tree below:

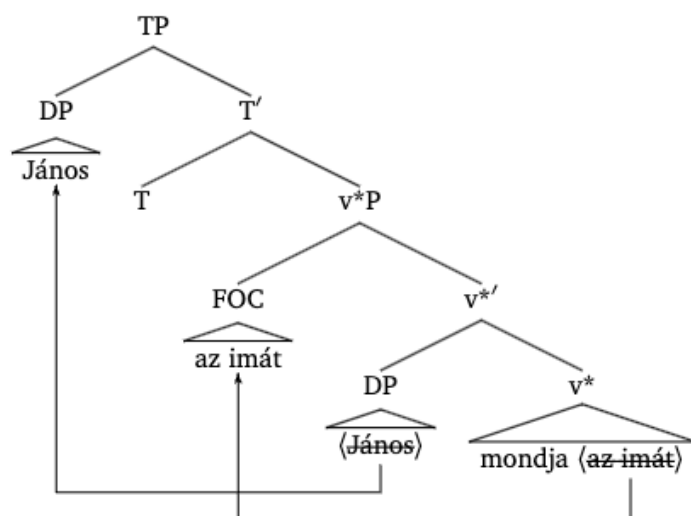
(6)



Intermediate derivation of (2)

- iv. Next, merge $[_{DP} \text{János 'John'}]$ to $v^{*'}$, checking the $[EPP]$ feature on $[_v \text{mondja 'says'}]$, projecting another $v^{*'}$. $[_{DP} \text{János 'John'}]$ enters the syntax with features $[\phi: 3SG]$ $[Case: _]$
- v. Internally merge $[_{DP} \text{az imát 'the prayer'}]$ to Spec- v^*P to check the $[FOC]$ features on DP and V .
- vi. Merge T , which carries the features $[PRES]$, $[Case: NOM]$, $[\phi: _]$ and $[EPP]$ to v^*P , and project T' . The $[EPP]$ feature on T triggers the movement of $[_{DP} \text{János 'John'}]$, which is at the edge of the phase v^*P , to Spec- TP . Agree and Feature Valuation occurs between T and $[_{DP} \text{János 'John'}]$. The final derivation is represented below:

(7)



Final Derivation of (2)

This representation of sentence (2) derives the correct surface order. All features have been checked, and the Phase Impenetrability Condition has not been violated. I thus conclude that the derivation process correctly generates Hungarian sentences of the variety examined thus far.

§3: A Description of *az*-Focusing

Sentences (5a-d) demonstrated that **DPs** (*János* ‘John’; *nyelvészetet* ‘linguistics-ACC’), **PPs** (*az egyetemen* ‘at the university’), and **AdvPs** (*tényleg* ‘indeed’) can fill the Focus position.³

However, not all phrases can be raised to Focus:

- (8) a. *{_{CP} Hogy beteg a lány } ész-re-vesz-em {_{CP} hogy beteg a lány}}
 *{ *That sick the girl* } *mind-SUBL-take-1SG* { *that sick the girl* }

INTENDED: ‘I notice that the girl is sick.’

- b. *{_{TP} Meg-en-ni a tortát } készül-nek {_{TP} meg-enni a tortát }
 *{ *COMPL-eat-INF the cake-ACC* } *prepare.PRS-3PL* { *COMPL-eat-INF the cake-ACC* }

INTENDED: ‘They are preparing to eat the cake.’

Sentence (8a) demonstrates that the insertion of a CP into Focus position is ungrammatical, while (8b) illustrates that the same is true for a TP.⁴

Az-focusing is thus required in order to construct sentences that place emphasis on a CP or a TP and yield the desired readings. Consider the following examples of *az*-focusing:

³ There does not appear to be a meaningful difference between DPs and PPs in Hungarian, as both can surface as DPs with suffixes that mark Case (however, it should be noted that some postpositions occur as a separate word: compare *ebédre* ‘for lunch’ and *ebéd után* ‘after lunch’).

⁴ It should be noted that, when the CP is moved to Focus, the string has another irrelevant possible parse whereby *a lány* ‘the girl’ is interpreted as occupying the Focus position, and is thus interpreted as the Nominative subject of the sentence, which is ungrammatical given that the verb carries 1SG ϕ - features.

- (9) a. Az-t (*Az-∅) *{ész-re} vesz-em {ész-re}, hogy beteg a lány
*AZ-ACC (*AZ-NOM) *{mind-SUBL} take-1SG {mind-SUBL} that sick the girl*
 ‘I notice that the girl is sick.’⁵
- b. Ar-ra (*Az-∅) (*Az-t) készül-nek, hogy [_{TP} meg-egy-ék
*AZ-SUBL (*AZ.NOM (*AZ-ACC) prepare.PRS-3PL that COMPL-eat.SBJV-3PL*
 a tortát]}
⁶ *the cake-ACC*
 ‘They are preparing to eat the cake.’⁷

(9a) and (9b) are modifications of (8a) and (8b), respectively, wherein a Case- and ϕ -inflected version of *az* is inserted into the focus position, and the TP and CP remain in their base position.

There are various possible explanations of why *az*-Focusing occurs. É. Kiss argues that the constraint has to do with the requirement that “Focus constituents must be head-final for some reason” (É. Kiss 2002: 88). Kenesei offers more specificity, claiming that the restriction against

⁵ Note that in sentence (9a), the movement of a *wh*-word into focus position also causes the decomposition of the agglutinated verb *észrevenni*, which appears in its typical compound form in (9b). In (9a), the prefix *észre* becomes a separate word that comes after the main verb *vesz*. (From a syntactic perspective, this may imply that the prefix remains in the V head position, and only the verb moves up to *v**.) This decomposition seems to indicate that Focus positioning targets the morphological unit immediately prior to the main verb; from a syntactic perspective, this may mean that V-to-*v** movement motivated by a Strong-V only targets the main verb when it carries a [FOC] feature, leaving the prefix in V position. Also see É. Kiss (2002: 83 and 233).

⁶ Note that the TP must be embedded into a CP to undergo *az*-Focusing. See Section 5 for a discussion of this fact.

⁷ (9a) and (9b) illustrate that *az*-focusing is only grammatical when *az* is marked with the appropriate Case endings matching the verb. Compare this with the adverb *úgy* (‘so’, ‘thus’, ‘in this way’), which appears in the Focus position alongside a particular subset of verbs and cause emphasis to be placed on the manner of executing an action:

- a. Úgy vél-em, hogy beteg a lány
so believe-1SG that sick the girl
 ‘I believe that the girl is sick’,
 ‘My beliefs are structured in a manner that acknowledges the girl’s illness’
- b. Úgy tervez-ik, hogy meg-egy-ék a tortát
so plan.PRS-3PL.DEF that COMPL-eat.SBJV-3PL the cake-ACC
 ‘They are planning to eat the cake’,
 ‘They are planning in a manner that results in their eating of the cake’

Unlike *az*, *úgy* does not take Case endings, which means that it can be accounted for under our current account of Focus: it is an example of AdvP movement to Focus position, as in (4e).

clauses in Focus is prosodic: the Focus constituent must constitute a single phonological phrase with the verb following it (Kenesei 2006: 25). Both of these claims capture the underlying sense that *az*-Focusing arises because of some restriction on moving a phrase that is too ‘big’ into the Focus position; the distinction between these options does not critically impact a syntactic explanation of how the phenomenon works.

§4: *az*-Focusing as Expletive Insertion

In our first attempt at serving a syntactic representation of *az*-Focusing, we follow the assumptions that *az* is Merged directly into Spec-v*P, through a process called Expletive Insertion. In Expletive Insertion, a function word is introduced for the purpose of checking a certain feature, and does not contribute semantic content. Like the English expletives ‘there’ and ‘it,’ *az* appears at the left periphery of the clause, and does not appear to carry semantic meaning. ‘Hypothesis I,’ introduced below, formalizes this concept:

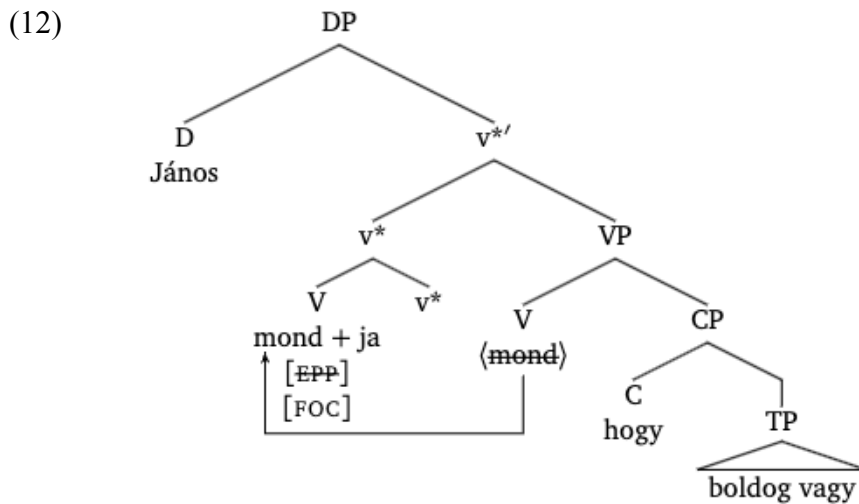
- (10) **HYPOTHESIS I**
When a phrase that cannot carry Case must be semantically emphasized, az is Merged directly into the Focus position to satisfy the syntactic requirement that the position is filled. Az enters the syntax unvalued in ϕ - and Case- features, which are valued through Agree.

Although Kenesei only touches on *az*-Focusing briefly, he seems to follow some version of Hypothesis I, referring in his account of the phenomenon to the “expletive *az* ‘it’” that can fill the “designated focus position” when it is “assigned appropriate case.” (Kenesei: 2006, 15).

Consider the derivation of the following sentence:

- (11) János az-t mond-ja, hogy boldog vagy
John AZ-ACC say-PRS.3SG that happy be.PRS.2SG
 ‘John says that you are happy.’

The derivation mirrors that of (2), steps 1-4, yielding the following intermediate derivation:



Intermediate Derivation of (12)

At this point, the [FOC] feature on V remains unchecked, but the CP cannot move to fill Spec-v*P because of the previously mentioned requirement that CPs cannot carry [FOC], since they cannot carry Case endings; and thus that they cannot check the feature on V.

We may here propose the External Merge of *az* into Spec-v*P as an instance of Expletive Insertion. However, this approach encounters a significant theoretical impediment: as evidenced by examples (11a) and (11b), *az* must undergo Agree to value its ϕ - and Case- values. However, it cannot engage in an Agree relationship with the Probe, in accordance with the Activity Condition, which stipulates the following:

THE ACTIVITY CONDITION

The Probe and the Goal have to be active, where being active means having uninterpretable/unvalued features. (Chomsky 2000: 122)

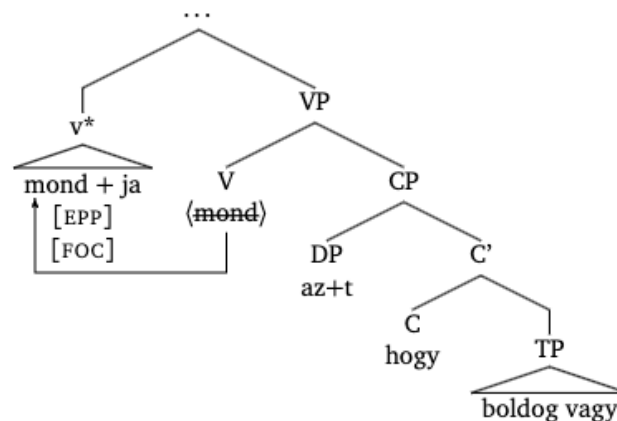
In this case, the Goal ($[_v \text{ mond}ja \text{ 'says'}]$) is not active, and so if *az* were inserted directly into Spec-v*P the construction would have unvalued features and the derivation would crash. Thus, it appears that *az* must value its features through Agree at the same time as the CP does, which entails that *az* is in fact Merged into the syntax earlier in the derivation.

An additional problem with Hypothesis I arises from the foundational assumption that the Focus position is typically reserved for semantic fronting. This position presupposes that elements within it bear semantic significance to warrant emphasis. Therefore, categorizing *az* as an expletive, inherently devoid of semantic content, appears contradictory to the established function of Focus in highlighting semantically pertinent information.

§5: *az*-Focusing as Internal Movement

Having rejected our theory posited in §3 of *az*-Focusing as Expletive Insertion, we instead entertain a new analysis of sentence (11) whereby *az* is Merged into the syntax as a DP in Spec-CP, before moving up to Spec-v*P.

(13)



One piece of evidence that supports this proposal is that the sentence (11) remains grammatical if *az* does not move upwards, and instead remains immediately in front of the CP (in this case, the sentence has the ‘unmarked’ SVO reading).

- (14) János mond-ja (az-t,) hogy boldog vagy
John say-PRS.3SG (AZ-ACC) that happy be.PRS.2SG
 ‘John says that you are happy.’

Moreover, recall that TPs must be embedded within a CP in order to take part in *az*-Focusing, illustrated in (10b).

- (10) b. Ar-ra (*Az-∅) (*Az-t) készül-nek, [_{CP} hogy [_{TP} meg-egy-ék
*AZ-SUBL (*AZ.NOM (*AZ-ACC) prepare.PRS-3PL that COMPL-eat.SBJV-3PL*
 a tortát]}
the cake-ACC }
 ‘They are preparing to eat the cake.’

This suggests that there is a syntactic requirement that [_{DP} *az*] must enter the syntax immediately dominated by a CP.

It should be noted that there is some crosslinguistic motivation for instead having *az* be a D head that Merges with the CP and projects a DP: for example, consider the English sentence “John said [_{DP} [_D this] : [_{CP} that [_{TP} you are happy]]].” However, the fact that Focused elements undergo long movement, and that all other Focused elements in Hungarian appear to be XPs, cause us to instead conclude that *az* is a DP. This conclusion prevents us from having to propose that *az*-Focusing is a type of Head Movement, which is judged as problematic for the Extension Condition by Harizanov & Gribanova (2017).

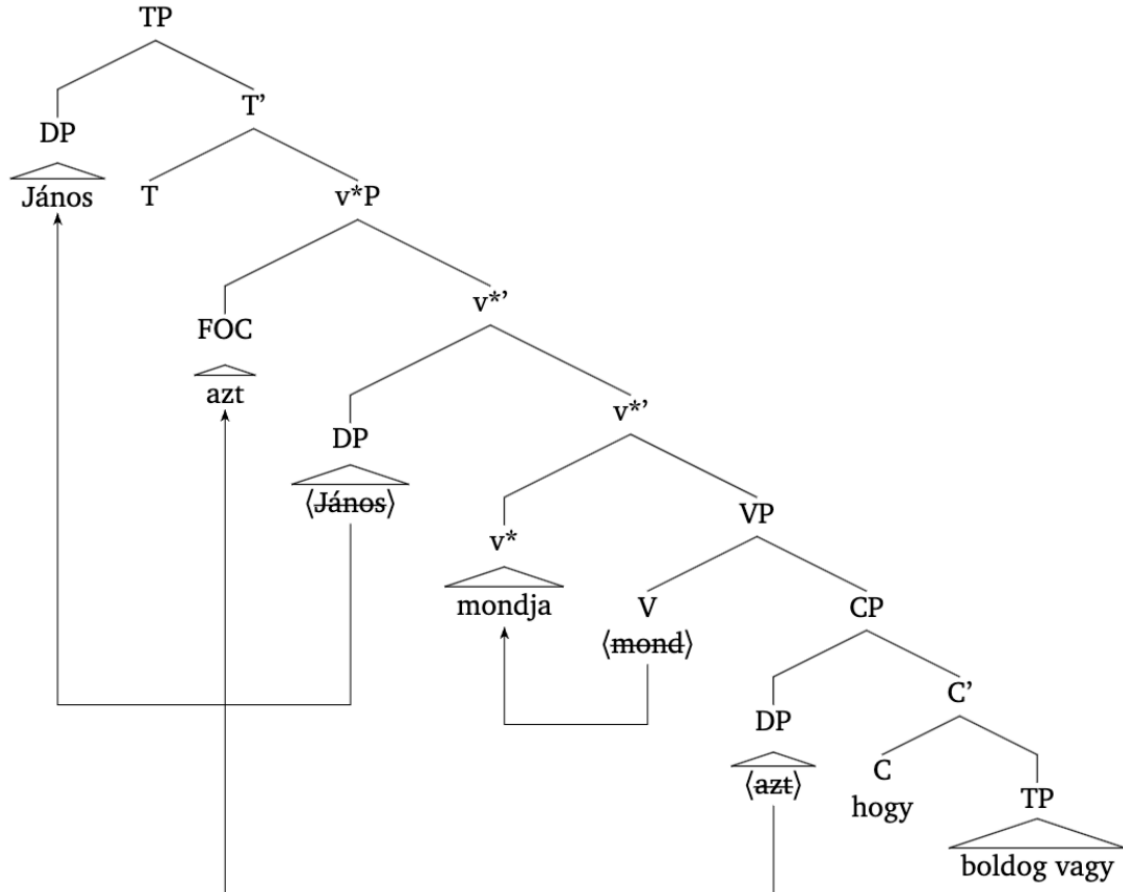
Hypothesis II, below, summarizes this alternative understanding of *az*-Focusing:

(15) **HYPOTHESIS II**

*Az enters the syntax as a DP in spec-CP, carrying [FOC]. The entire CP enters an Agree relationship with V, causing the valuation of all unvalued ϕ - and Case-features. Finally, through Internal Merge, it ends up in spec- v^*P , where its [FOC] feature is checked against the V's [FOC] feature.*

We now attempt once more to derive sentence (11), proceeding from the intermediate structure depicted in (13). The derivation proceeds with the Merging of [_{DP} *János* 'John'] into the syntax, and finally the movement upwards of [_{DP} *János* 'John'] and [_{DP} *azt*] to check the [EPP] and [FOC] features on v^* , respectively. The final derivation of (11) appears below:

(16)



This derivation yields the correct surface order, and all uninterpretable features have been deleted. Thus, we conclude that Hypothesis II is an appropriate explanation of Hungarian *az*-Focusing.

§6: Conclusion

Analysis of Hungarian word order reveals that Focus positioning can be understood as a (phonological and) syntactic process whereby certain phrases (DP, PP, VP, AdvP), carrying a [FOC] feature, undergo movement to Spec-v*P, the preverbal Focus position, in order to undergo feature checking with V, which also carries a [FOC] feature. The challenges that Hypothesis I raises for a Minimalist framework, as well as the suitability of Hypothesis II in deriving correct sentences displaying *az*-Focusing, allows us to conclude that the Hungarian demonstrative *az* is a semantically-null DP that is first Merged into a lower spec-CP, rather than an expletive Merged in at Spec-v*P. These findings may be extendable to other languages that appear to have a particular syntactic position associated with Focus, whether or not this position happens to be preverbal.

Questions remain about the exact nature of the relationship between *az* and the CP it is the specifier of: is there a way to formally encode the requirement that the initial position of *az* must be in Spec-CP? Moreover, the relationship between *az* as it co-occurs with CPs, and its use as a general demonstrative meaning ‘that,’ has not been sufficiently analyzed. It remains unclear why, for example, inflected versions of *az* appear in the Focus position rather than inflected versions of *ez* (‘this’). Such research could lead to a more unified model of how Hungarian syntax and semantics interface.

§7: References

Works Cited

- Chomsky, Noam, 2000: 'Minimalist Inquiries: The Framework.' In: Martin, R., Michaels, D. and Uriagereka, J., Eds., *Step by Step: Essays on Minimalist Syntax in Honor of Howard Lasnik*, MIT Press.
- É. Kiss, Katalin, 2002: *The Syntax of Hungarian*. Cambridge University Press.
- Harizanov, Boris & Gribanova, Vera, 2019: 'Whither head movement?'. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory*. 37.
- Horváth, Julia, 1995: 'Structural Focus, Structural Case, and the Notion of Feature-Assignment.' In K. É. Kiss, ed., *Discourse Configurational Languages*, Oxford Studies in Comparative Syntax. Oxford University Press.
- Kenesei, István, 2006: 'Focus as Identification,' in *The Architecture of Focus*, ed. Molnár, Valéria et al. De Gruyter.
- Lipták, Anikó. 2003: 'The expression of sentential emphasis in Hungarian.' [manuscript]
- Jackendoff, Ray. 1972: 'Chapter 6: Focus and Presupposition,' in *Semantic Interpretation in Generative Grammar*. MIT Press.
- Rounds, Carol, 2009: *Hungarian: An Essential Grammar (2nd ed)*. Routledge Essential Grammars.
- Szendrői, Kriszta, 2017: 'Focus Movement.' In *The Wiley Blackwell Companion to Syntax (2nd ed)*. John Wiley & Sons, Inc.

Other Works Consulted

- Bánréti, Zoltán, ed. 2022: *Syntax of Hungarian: Coordination and Ellipsis*. Amsterdam University Press.
- Benincà, Paola & Munaro, Nicola, eds. 2010: *Mapping the Left Periphery*. Oxford University Press.
- Citko, Barbara, 2014: *Phase Theory: An Introduction (1st ed.)*. Cambridge University Press.
- Horváth, Julia, 1986: *FOCUS in the Theory of Grammar and the Syntax of Hungarian. Volume 24 in the series Studies in Generative Grammar*.
- Puskás, Genoveva, 2000: *Word Order in Hungarian: The syntax of $\bar{A}$ -positions*. John Benjamins Publishing Company.
- Radford, Andrew, 2009: *Analyzing English Sentences: A Minimalist Approach*. Cambridge University Press.
- Spector, Benjamin & Egré, Paul, 2015: ‘A uniform semantics for embedded interrogatives: *an* answer, not necessarily *the* answer.’ *Synthese*, Vol. 192, No. 67
- Svenonius, Peter, 2019: ‘Prepositions with CP and their implications for extended projections.’ [manuscript]